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Part 1

You are going to read a newspaper article about sailing in single-handed boats known as 'Oppies'. Choose from the list A-I the sentence which best summarises each part (1-7) of the article. There is one extra sentence which you do not need to use. There is an example at the beginning (0).

Mark your answers on the separate answer sheet.

- A Sailing tends to run in families.
- B There's no hiding these sailors' ambitions.
- C Sailors are used to waiting around.
- D Overcoming problems is part of the challenge of sailing.
- E Enthusiasm about sailing was infectious.
- F There's always more you can learn about sailing.
- G Some basics about sailing were explained.
- H These sailors have other talents.
- I The sailing conditions weren't as good as I thought.

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Rock the Boat

0 It was windy when I arrived in Largs. Not much sun but perfect for sailing, I thought. As I fought the gale to shut my car door, I noticed there were lots of people around but no sailing boats in the choppy grey water. It was race day, so what was going on?

1 The boats, or 'Oppies' as they are affectionately called, were lying bottom-up on the beach, their sails tightly wrapped beside them. 'There's been a delay,' the race organiser said, pointing at two flags waving in the breeze. He said the red-and-white-striped one meant that there was a delay, while the red, white and blue one meant it would be for three hours.

2 No-one looks disappointed, probably because they are accustomed to being ruled by the weather. Competitors — casually dressed in baggy shorts, T-shirts, deck shoes and an assortment of anoraks and baseball caps — played on bikes or skateboards or just chatted to kill the time. Spectators sat in groups in the clubhouse, eating rolls and drinking tea.

3 I suddenly felt very pale and 'indoorsy' as I sat down with some of the tanned, blond champs. Nicky Barnes, 15, Elliot Willis, 14, Eddie Huntley, 13, and Paul Campbell-Jones, 14, have been sailing for years, and certainly have the sea in their blood. Paul's dad sailed in the Olympics and Nicky started sailing because her dad dragged her along. 'I was terrified at first,' she confesses. Recently they successfully competed at the world championships.

4 Varying degrees of hard work go into their preparation, but Nicky does the most. She trains in winter and says it is hard, 'especially when all your friends are out partying'. Then she practises techniques, boat handling and wind strategy. Meanwhile, Elliot had learned how the shape of clouds and hills affects the wind. Eddie is more relaxed and a bit more confident about it: 'I don't like training. I've got better things to do.'

5 They all get on well, joking and teasing each other, but out on the water, competition is fierce. Paul doesn't hesitate to say the best thing about sailing is winning. They've all had nasty moments, but no-one will admit to falling in. The boys happily told me of Nicky's fear of fish, and Elliot tells a good tale about his boat being hit by a shark.

6 Other sports, they stressed, tend to take second place: Elliot could play cricket for his area but doesn't, and Nicky plays hockey, 'but I'm not allowed to do it before big events'. The comments of their non-sailing friends about their boatie lifestyles ranged from 'a bit weird' to 'really cool'. Elliot thinks that only people who are jealous want to make fun of them.

7 With the three-hour delay nearly up, the excitement was building. People struggled into their wetsuits and started preparing their boats. The wind was still strong and the black clouds racing, but they couldn't wait to get out. It might just have been the weather, but I had to agree that the Oppie sailing scene was 'really cool'.

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Turn over

Part 2

You are going to read a magazine article about a radio presenter. For questions 8-14, choose the answer (A, B, C or D) which you think fits best according to the text.

Mark your answers on the separate answer sheet.

A New Voice on the Radio

Margherita Taylor talks to Sarah Edghill about what it's like being at Capital Radio.

Margherita Taylor is the only female presenter at Capital Radio, one of London's top music radio stations. She got into radio while she was a student in Birmingham. Along with hundreds of other hopefuls, she and a friend queued for hours in the rain to take part in a 'Search for a Star' competition held by a local radio station, BRMB. 'I had to read a travel script and a weather script, talk about myself for a minute, then introduce a record. After that, they sent me back out into the rain,' she says. But within days the phone call came to say that her voice had earned her a regular show on BRMB. Truly the stuff dreams are made of. After working there for eighteen months, she was offered a job with Capital.

Margherita is a London girl and arriving at Capital was like coming home. 'I grew up listening to Capital Radio,' she says. 'People say, "Wasn't it frightening, joining such well-known presenters?" But everyone here is so down to earth. It would be off-putting if the others had people doing their make-up, or star signs on their office doors. But there's none of that — Mick Brown, for instance, finishes his show and wanders off to get the bus home with everyone else.'

Margherita claims never to get nervous before a show — nerves are for the weak. 'You can't get nervous because then you make mistakes,' she says. Of course, there has been the odd disaster. 'For instance, when I did my first live concert show at BRMB, I'd only done one programme. In front of a crowd of 50,000, I went on stage to introduce a certain well-known singer. I said: "Please welcome our next performer. You know her best for hits like ..." Then I just went blank. There was this silence from the crowd, and for the life of me I couldn't think what she'd sung. That's one occasion that will stay with me for ever.'

Margherita says that her own musical tastes are varied. But she doesn't pick her own music for her shows. The Capital computer selects the records in advance from a list approved by the station managers. 'The station has a certain sound, and if we all picked our own music, it wouldn't sound like Capital,' she says. 'But for someone who likes music, this is a dream job. I get to go to concerts and meet the bands you can hear on my show. It's great to hear the "behind the scenes" gossip.'

Most people would expect that a presenter's most important qualities are a nice voice and huge amounts of confidence, but Margherita says that basic maths is handy as well. 'You have to make sure that you've got an eye on everything that's going on in the studio, but you've got to be able to add and subtract and think in minutes and seconds,' she says. 'You're dealing with timed records, and with announcements and commercials that are also timed precisely, and you have to be ready to switch to the news at exactly the right second. If you're going over to a live event, you need to be ready for that on time, not a second earlier or later.'

This isn't the sort of girl to let the rock 'n' roll lifestyle go to her head. Even if she did, her family would bring her down to earth. 'When I started at Capital the only thing my brothers asked was whether they'd get free records,' she remembers. 'And my mum couldn't even find the station on her radio.'

Margherita Taylor is very nice and very easy-going, but very much in control. She is so much a 'Capital Radio girl' that you might think she is just doing a good job for the station's publicity department, although you know what she's saying really comes from the heart. She smiles a lot, laughs a lot and is generally a great advert for Capital.

8 What do we learn about Margherita in the first paragraph?

- A She became a radio presenter by chance.
- B She expected to win the competition.
- C She was keen to become a radio presenter.
- D She practised before the competition.

9 What does 'that' in line 25 refer to?

- A the fame of the other presenters
- B Margherita's fear of the other staff
- C self-important behaviour by the other presenters
- D bad treatment of Margherita by the other staff

10 What do we learn about Margherita's first live concert show?

- A It is the only time she has made a serious mistake.
- B Being nervous was not the cause of the problem.
- C People often remind her of what happened then.
- D She had not expected to have the problem she had.

11 One point Margherita makes about her job is that she

- A has changed her attitude to music.
- B is unhappy that the records she plays are chosen for her.
- C likes most of the music that she plays on her show.
- D enjoys talking to the people whose records she plays.

12 What does Margherita say about presenting a show?

- A It is essential to keep in mind what is going to happen next.
- B It is more complicated than she had previously thought.
- C The ability to add and subtract is the most important requirement.
- D The content of a show is sometimes changed suddenly.

13 How have Margherita's family reacted to her success?

- A with caution
- B without interest
- C with surprise
- D without excitement

14 In the final paragraph, the writer says that Margherita

- A was different from what she had expected.
- B genuinely believes that Capital is a good radio station.
- C feels it necessary to talk about Capital Radio all the time.
- D has already changed her job at Capital Radio.

Part 4

You are going to read a newspaper article in which people talk about where they played as children. For questions 21-26, choose from the people (A-G), and for questions 27-35, choose which person's play area (A-G) is referred to. The people and play areas may be chosen more than once. When more than one answer is required, these may be given in any order. There is an example at the beginning (0).

Mark your answers on the separate answer sheet.

Which person

developed sporting skills?

0	B
---	---

mentions not going straight home from school?

21	
----	--

still retains a sense of wonder at something seen in childhood?

22	
----	--

enjoyed a game that could only be played with a specially shaped object?

23	
----	--

enjoyed both being alone and with friends?

24	
----	--

played with a family member?

25	
----	--

now realises how lucky they were?

26	
----	--

Whose play area(s)

were neglected?

27		28	
----	--	----	--

is no longer the same?

29	
----	--

seemed similar to a jail?

30	
----	--

are described as a contrast to the home environment?

31		32	
----	--	----	--

were made to substitute for something else?

33		34	
----	--	----	--

was in a forbidden area?

35	
----	--

A Place to Play

We asked various people to tell us about where they played as children, and here's what they said ...

A Simon

The playground was quite small. The floor was covered with flat bricks and there were many that were cracked or broken or missing, and a few weeds struggled through. It was totally enclosed on one side by the school and on the other by high brick walls. It was more like a prison yard -- on top of the walls was a layer of cement into which pieces of broken glass had been stuck. After school was finished my friends and I would climb a lamppost outside the school and sit on top of the wall, slowly breaking off the bits of glass. We never thought of ourselves as vandals.

B Peter

My favourite childhood play area was the back garden. Back in the days when I was growing up on a large housing estate, the 'goals' would be a pair of garage doors or two jackets laid out in the garden. I would spend hours kicking a ball about with my dad, learning how to control, dribble or kick it.

C Alan

I come from an area of terraced houses, pavements and streets. There were no gardens. My first school was Pince's Street Primary and the room in which I received my first lessons had large, folding glass doors that opened onto a small playground that had grass, bushes and flowers. My amazement at seeing these items, which are normal to most of the world, has stayed with me all my life.

D Nigel

My favourite play area was -- it still is -- called Roundhead Wood, although it has fewer trees and more barbed wire now. Here four or five of us roared around, building camps, climbing trees and riding bikes around the little chalk pit in the middle. It stood for every woodland, every jungle and even the surface of other planets.

E Patricia

One of my earliest playground memories is of the railed playground in front of the school I attended. Our favourite game was hopscotch, which was played by marking out a rectangle divided into squares and kicking a flat, rounded stone from square to square. It was important to find a stone of precisely the right size and weight. Our playground at weekends was more exciting: the banks and paths which surrounded Ludlow Castle and the water meadows that stretched down to the river. I doubt whether I fully appreciated how fortunate we were.

F Nick

I was strictly banned from the obvious playground, a long, overgrown ditch running through waste ground, mainly built to take away the rain. It was irresistible to us local schoolchildren. Its charm, compared with the surrounding tennis courts, football pitches and farmland, was purely because it was out of bounds. That area was truly where I grew up, more than in the rest of the little town's correct and neat suburbia, where my house was.

G Julie

Until I was twelve I was brought up on airforce camps and each camp had a small playground in the middle of the houses. It was always a great meeting place and I remember sitting with my friends on the swings many evenings until dark. You would often go out and swing for hours until someone else came out. I always liked swinging.

You are going to read an extract from a book about a man's experiences of climbing in Wales. Seven paragraphs have been removed from the extract. Choose from the paragraphs **A-H** the one which fits each gap (**15-20**). There is one extra paragraph which you do not need to use. There is an example at the beginning (**0**).

Mark your answers **on the separate answer sheet**.

Welsh Mountains

0 'Taking in!' The words floated down from on high to be swiftly followed by the tightening of the climbing rope by my feet. I shouted automatically, 'That's me!'

0

H

It all seemed very familiar, but for many years my climbing rope had hung frustratingly at the foot of my stairs, and I was now sixty. John, my old climbing partner on so many climbs, had suggested that we might climb again together.

15

John and I had shared so many memorable climbs. My mind went back to the last long climb that we had enjoyed together, which was on Lliwedd mountain during a June heatwave. The streams had dried up and all the grasses were burnt yellow by the sun. As we neared the cliff and stopped for a rest, John suddenly disappeared to return some considerable time later clutching a small plastic bag filled with the coolest, clearest water that you could imagine.

16

We climbed in the shadow of a great cliff. We finally arrived at the top of the climb on the west summit. To our amazement, we saw that storm clouds were tumbling over the Nantlle hills like a huge waterfall, their progress slow, but threatening.

17

We collected the rope and hurried down to our camp, racing against nature. John cooked our dinner as the first rumbles of distant thunder sent us hurrying into the tent.

18

We no longer needed a plastic bag to catch the water. The rain came down in sheets, drumming on the tent, but we were dry in our man-made cavern, fascinated by the power and the majesty of the storm around us.

19

Then suddenly I felt a gentle tug on the rope, followed by a more urgent one, suggesting that I make a move. 'Climbing!' I shouted, and started up the steep slab above. When I neared the top, I could see John's feet dangling in space. He had obviously found somewhere comfortable to sit and look at the view.

20

I can still share the wild hills with the wind and the rain. They are my mountains of longing; when I am not there my only wish is to return, for they have been my friends for so long.

A Finally, it died away like the outgoing tide and, in the deepening silence, sleep drifted into the tent. The next day would bring another adventure.

B I took no persuading, and so here I was. The legs didn't bend so easily now, but the spirit was more than willing. The thrill of climbing was still the same, and conquering the next few feet of rock was just as exciting as always.

C As I got closer, he peered down, grinning from ear to ear. 'Daydreaming?' he enquired. Nothing had changed. Time had marched on and my limbs were a little stiffer, but the hills were the same.

D It was heaven. I had wondered what was taking so long; he had found some trickling over mosses and with great patience had captured half a cupful in the plastic bag. We took it in turns to have a sip until it had gone and then plodded across the hillside to our chosen route.

E A storm in the hills is an experience not to be missed. We completed our meal, and crept into our sleeping bags. Thunder echoed around the hills and lightning lit the landscape. Sleep would not come and we lay there marvelling at the power of nature.

F I needn't have worried: he was up in no time and it was all that I could do to take the rope in fast enough. We set off down the mountains as fast as we dared in the conditions.

G We ignored their presence and relaxed in the evening sunlight, watching their relentless progress out of the corner of our eyes for some considerable time, until the truth suddenly dawned upon us: our heatwave was coming to a sudden end.

H What was I saying and what was I doing standing on a thin rock ledge, tied to a spike of rock with space below my feet and the mountains of Snowdonia spread out before me?